

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit II – Empathy and Problem Definition · Presentation 2 of 6

Empathy Mapping

Empathy as evidence · the say–do gap · three ways to gather it · the four quadrants · pains and gains · reading a finished map

Dr. Anantha Raman L., M.E., Ph.D. · Associate Professor, Department of Mechanical Engineering, Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology, Chennai

In this presentation

- Empathy is evidence, not sympathy
- The say–do gap
- Three ways to gather empathy
- The empathy map canvas
- What goes in each quadrant
- Pains and gains
- How to fill one in
- Reading a finished map

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What empathy means in design

A working method, not a good intention

Empathy is evidence, not sympathy

- Sympathy is feeling for someone; empathy is understanding their situation well enough to act on it
- In design it is a method: go, watch, ask, record, share
- It produces artefacts – notes, quotations, photographs, maps
- It is checkable: another person should read your notes and reach your conclusion

KEY POINT If your empathy work produced nothing anyone else can examine, you have not done empathy work. You have had a feeling.

The say–do gap

- People report what they intend, what they remember, and what sounds reasonable
- What they actually do is often different – and they are not lying to you
- Habits are invisible to the person who has them
- So ask and watch. Where the two disagree, you have found something

KEY POINT The gap between what people say and what they do is where the best design opportunities hide.

Three ways to gather empathy

Immerse

Live the experience yourself, even briefly. Ride the bus, queue at the counter, try it one-handed.

Observe

Watch people in their own setting, without interrupting what they are doing.

Engage

Talk to them about specific things that actually happened, not about what they would do.

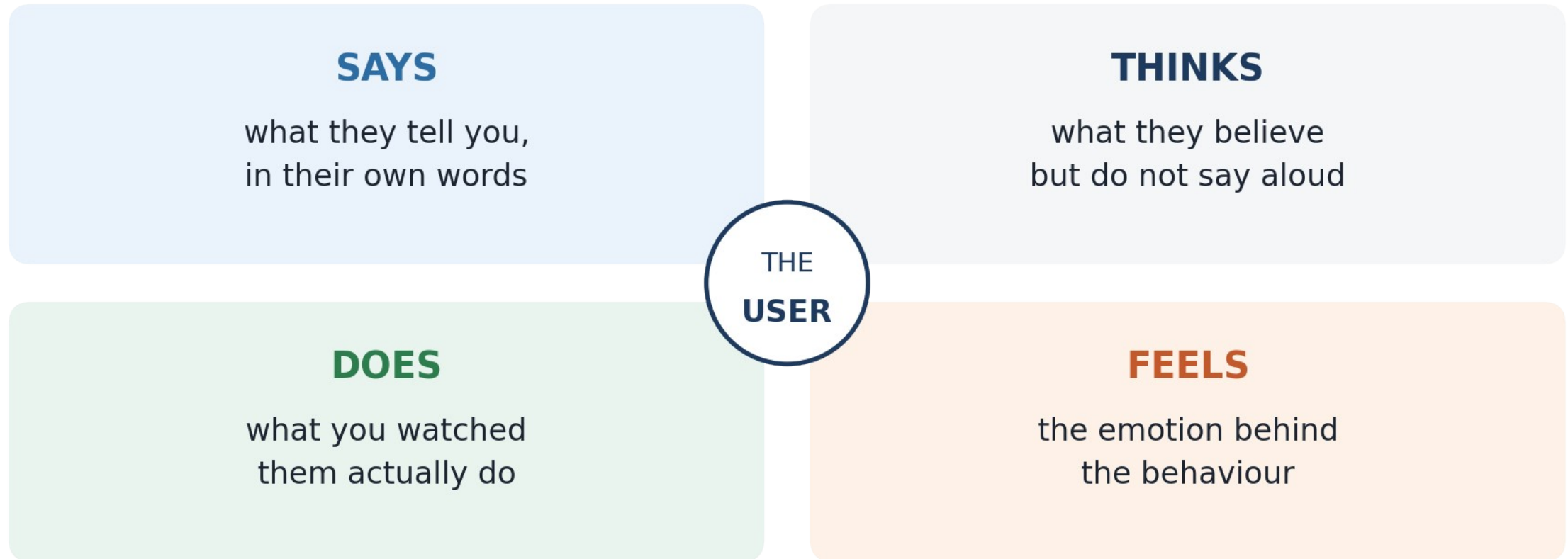
KEY POINT Use all three. Each one catches what the other two miss.

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The empathy map

One page that holds everything you learned about one person

The empathy map canvas



One map per real person – never one map for “the user”.

What goes in each quadrant

SAYS

Direct quotations, in their words. If it is not in quotation marks it does not belong here.

THINKS

What they believe but will not say aloud. This is inferred, so mark it as an inference.

DOES

Actions you watched them perform. Verbs only – no interpretation and no adjectives.

FEELS

The emotion behind the behaviour: rushed, worried, embarrassed, proud, resigned.

Pains and gains

PAINS

- What frustrates or blocks them
- Risks and fears they carry
- Costs in time, money and effort
- Workarounds they invented

GAINS

- What they are trying to achieve
- How they measure success
- What would genuinely delight them
- What they already do well

KEY POINT A workaround is a pain and a design brief at once – somebody has already built you a prototype.

How to fill one in

- One map per person, not one per team – average people do not exist
- Fill it straight from your notes, while they are still fresh
- Use one colour for what you observed and another for what you inferred
- Leave the gaps visible; an empty quadrant tells you what to go back for

ACTIVITY Twenty minutes. Interview a classmate about their journey to college, then build one map each and compare what you each wrote down.

Reading a finished map

- Look for contradictions between Says and Does – that is the gap
- Look for emotion with no visible cause; you have missed part of the story
- Look for the same pain across several maps; that is a pattern, not an anecdote
- Then write one sentence: what surprised you most?

KEY POINT The contradictions are the point. A map with no tension in it usually means you only asked questions.

Common mistakes

- Filling it in from imagination rather than from notes
- Writing your solution into the map as though it were a need
- One map for “the user” instead of one per real person
- Treating it as a form to complete rather than a tool to argue over

THINK ABOUT IT

What is one thing you do every day that you would never think to mention in an interview?

- What made you stop noticing it?
- Who else does the same thing without saying so?
- How would an observer have spotted it?
- What would a designer do with that information?

Summary

- Empathy is a method that produces evidence others can check
- People report intentions; observation catches behaviour
- Immerse, observe and engage – each catches different things
- Says, Thinks, Does and Feels, one map per real person
- Pains and gains; a workaround is both a pain and a brief
- Contradictions in a map are the finding, not an error

Next: Observation techniques

- What people genuinely cannot tell you
- How involved the observer should be
- The AEIOU framework in the field
- Recording fieldwork, and ethics on site